INDIA TODAY
www.indiatoday.in

CHAIRMAN AND EDITOR-IN-CHIEF: Aroon Purie
VICE CHAIRPERSON AND EXECUTIVE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF: Kalli Purie
GROUP CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER: Dinesh Bhatia

GROUP EDITORIAL DIRECTOR: Raj Chengappa

CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER: Manoj Sharma

GROUP CREATIVE EDITOR & CHIEF OF AI : Nilanjan Das **GROUP PHOTO EDITOR:** Bandeep Singh
EDITOR (FEATURES): Kai Jabir Friese
MANAGING EDITORS: Sunil Menon, S. Sahaya Ranjit, Manisha Saroop, Kaushik Deka
MUMBAI: M.G. Arun
SENIOR DEPUTY EDITORS: Anilesh S. Mahajan, Sangram K. Parhi, Sasi Nair
DEPUTY EDITORS: Pradip R. Sagar
JAIPUR: Rohit Parihar; MUMBAI: Suhani Singh
SENIOR EDITORS: Sonali Acharjee, Ashish Mukherjee, Saikat Niyogi
PATNA: Amitabh Srivastava; BHOPAL: Rahul Noronha
SENIOR ASSOCIATE EDITORS: Sonal Khetarpal
MUMBAI: Dhaval S . Kulkarni; AHMEDABAD: Jumana Shah
ASSOCIATE EDITOR: Avishek G. Dastidar, Vipul Grover; BENGALURU: Ajay Sukumaran
ASSISTANT EDITOR: KOLKATA: Arkamoy Datta Majumdar
PRINCIPAL CORRESPONDENT: LUCKNOW: Avaneesh Mishra
PHOTO DEPARTMENT: Chandra Deep Kumar, Rajwant Singh Rawat (Deputy Chief Photographers), Arun Kumar (Principal Photographer)
MUMBAI: Mandar Suresh Deodhar (Chief Photographer)
PHOTO RESEARCHERS: Prabhakar Tiwari (Deputy Visual Research Editor), Saloni Vaid (Chief Photo Researcher), Jodha Singh Adhikari (Principal Photo Researcher)
GRAPHICS EDITOR: Tanmoy Chakraborty
ART DEPARTMENT: Sanjay Piplani (Creative Editor), Angshuman De (Senior Art Director), Rajesh Kumar Angira, Bhoomesh Dutt Sharma (Associate Art Directors), Santosh Kumar Sharma (Assistant Art Director), Praveen Kumar Gummadi (Chief Designer), Siddhant Jumde (Chief Illustrator)
PRODUCTION DEPARTMENT: Harish Agarwal (Chief of Production), Naveen Gupta (Chief Coordinator)

CHIEF OPERATING OFFICER
Suparna Kumar

IMPACT TEAM
Senior General Managers: Jitendra Lad (West and East), Syed Naveed (Chennai)
General Manager: Mohan Bisht (North)
Deputy General Manager: Raghunandan P (Bengaluru)
GROUP CHIEF MARKETING OFFICER: Vivek Malhotra

SALES AND OPERATIONS
Deepak Bhatt, Assistant Vice President-Sales and Distribution
Rajeev Gandhi, General Manager (North)
Yogesh Godhanlal Gautam, Regional Sales Manager (West)
Manawer Hossain, Regional Sales Manager (East)

INDIA TODAY GROUP

Volume 50-Number 50; For the week December 9-15, 2025, published on every Friday

• Editorial/Corporate Office Living Media India Ltd., India Today Group Mediaplex, FC-8, Sector-16A, Film City, Noida - 201301; Phone: 0120-4807100 • Subscriptions: For assistance, contact, email: wecare@intoday.com; Phone / Whatsapp: +91 8597 778 778 (Monday to Saturday, 9.30am – 5.30pm). • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, C-9, Sector-10, Noida-201301 (UP). • Regd. Office: F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001. • Impact Offices: 1201, 12th Floor, Tower 2 A, One Indiabulls Centre, (Jupiter Mills), S.B. Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai-400013; Phone: 022 69193355; Fax: 66063226 • E-1, Ground Floor, Videocon Towers, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi. • Door No: 610, 610A, 612, 5th Floor, Block A, Imperial Chaitanya Building, Anna Salai, Teynampet, Chennai, Tamilnadu-600018. • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825398; Fax: 22827254; • 6-3-885/7/B, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 • 39/1045, Karakkatt Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058 ; Fax: 2377059 • 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 • Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited.
Printed and published by Manoj Sharma on behalf of Living Media India Limited. Printed at Thomson Press India Private Limited, 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana) and at Rajhans Enterprises, 134, Industrial Town, 4th Main Road, Rajajinagar, Bengaluru-560044, (Karnataka).

Published at F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001.

Editor: Raj Chengappa.

• INDIA TODAY does not take the responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only

SYNDICATIONS TODAY INDIA DELIVERED
For **reprint rights** and **syndication** enquiries, contact syndications@intoday.com or call +91-120-4078000
www.syndicationstoday.in

CONTENTS

UPFRONT: HOW TO KEEP GROWTH ON TRACK *PG 6*

STATESCAN: AYODHYA IN A NEW AVATAR *PG 16*



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

COVER STORY

Putin with PM Modi and President Murmu

'CAN'T ARM-TWIST INDIA'

Exclusive interview with Russian president Vladimir Putin

▶ **BJP**

38 New Battlefronts
Buoyed by the landslide victory in Bihar, the BJP enters 2026 with its sights set on West Bengal and the South

▶ **PM'S INTERN SCHEME**

44 A Tepid Response
The government's attempts to give young job-seekers corporate exposure see underwhelming uptake

▶ **MAOISM**

48 The Big Surrender
A blend of force and persuasion fuels record surrenders in Bastar, quickening the push to end the movement

▶ **SPORTS**

52 Raft of New Leagues
Golf, volleyball, and even pickleball and arm-wrestling are being packaged into franchise-based leagues

▶ **LEISURE**

57 Her Defining Moment
Yami Gautam's stellar performance in *Haq*, and her rise as an actress

Note to the reader
From time to time, you will see pages titled 'An Impact Feature' or 'Focus' in INDIA TODAY. These are no different from advertisements, and the magazine's editorial staff is not involved in their creation in any way.

Cover by **NILANJAN DAS**
Photographs courtesy: Press Office of the President of the Russian Federation & Manish Mathur/India Today

INDIA TODAY GROUP

Readers are recommended to make appropriate enquiries before sending money, incurring expenses or entering into commitments in relation to any advertisement appearing in this publication. The India Today Group does not vouch for any claims made by the advertisers of products and services. The printer, publisher, editor-in-chief and the editor of the India Today Group publications shall not be held liable for any consequences in the event of such claims not being honoured by the advertisers.

SCAN HERE TO SUBSCRIBE

FOR SUBSCRIPTION ASSISTANCE, CONTACT:
email: wecare@intoday.com | Phone / Whatsapp: +91 8597 778 778
(Monday to Saturday, 9.30am - 5.30pm)

E-MAIL to:
letters.editor@intoday.com or
log on to **www.indiatoday.in**